

What would you do if one day your family told you that you are migrating permanently to a new country next week. No time to say goodbye to family and friends or even understand the shock, just pack and board. This is the reality sam faced when his family decided to move to the US

Sam is a 19 year old Lebanese living in the US. He moved to the Us back in the 11th grade, then graduated high school and majored in finance but all it took was one boring accounting class to make him change to a Cs major

Before coming to the US, Sam had a great life in Lebanon where he was surrounded by family and friends, always hanging out and enjoying the social life that Lebanon offers.

But everything changed when his mother and sister went to the US to visit his aunt. At first it was just a normal visit but his aunt tried convincing his mother to consider moving with her family to the US and it did work especially because this was back in late 2020 and we all know that 2020 was a difficult year for Lebanon from the economic downfall to the port explosion and everyone was overall depressed and looking to migrate. And this was the push for Sam and his family to move to the US in search for a better future even though there wasn't much time to process what was happening.

So Sam and his brother followed his mother and sister but his father had to stay in Lebanon to support them financially. This was one of the hardest parts for Sam because he was close to his father and suddenly each one of them is in a separate country, so it was painful

for both. Sam also felt a sense of guilt knowing that he was starting a new life while his father has to live on his own.

Like many immigrants, Before arriving to the US sam's mind was filled with American highschooler movies where he thought that life would be all fun, parties and games. But reality hit him hard. School was not as exciting as it seemed in movies. In fact it was boring and he even claimed that the educational system was actually worse than the Lebanese educational system.

To support himself, sam started working at a Lebanese restaurant . At first it was a job to help him pay his expenses and tuition but then it became a place of comfort where he met Lebanese and

arab colleagues making him feel at home. This job also gave him a sense of responsibility knowing he has to work to sustain himself

Despite the presence of Arabs, fitting in was challenging. American norms and values were really different from what he was used to. Even the way his friends hang out was unfamiliar to him. Back in Lebanon, socializing was about gatherings visiting each other and causal hangouts. In the Us his friends had different interests and routines

Unlike many immigrants sam made sure to stay connected to his Lebanese roots. He speaks Arabic with his family, listen to

Lebanese and Arabic music and stay in touch with his friends and family back home

However, One of his biggest challenges was his accent insecurities. He preferred making friends with other Lebanese or at least Arabs rather than Americans because he was afraid of getting judged by his colleagues for his accent. he would even hesitate to ask questions in class to avoid speaking outloud. At one point he even tried practicing the American accent.

Unfortunately, discrimination was another challenge for him and his family, when they would go out they often received strange looks especially because his mother wears a hijab. These experiences made them uncomfortable so they avoided going out frequently. Also, in the classroom teachers used different explanation methods for him like using simpler language and this was frustrating for Sam because ironically he was one of the best students in his class.

Beyond personal struggles, sam was affected by the war on Lebanon and Gaza. First emotionally seeing the death, destruction and suffering made him feel some sense of guilt knowing that he was living in a peaceful place with access to

everything he desired while his family and friends were struggling without their basic needs.

He even avoided talking with people in order to avoid this topic and the trouble for himself. Many of his American friends checked in on him, asking if his family was okay, which he appreciated. But at the same time, he felt that the general public was misinformed because the media wasn't showing the full reality of the situation.

Looking beyond his personal experiences Sam seems interested in the new US administrations but also has some worries about strict policies regarding immigrants like delay in paperwork or even getting a visa for his father . He is also worried about

potential cut of US aid program since it directly affects many of his friends for their education and he even has an aunt who is a researcher at LAU in a department funded by US aid.

In conclusion Sam's journey has been really difficult. It tested his resilience and shaped his identity. Now as he looks toward the future Sam's priority is to complete his bachelor in CS and build a career as a software engineer. And while he holds hopes to the future of Lebanon, he acknowledges that for the time being, the United States offers better opportunities for him. He is even open to move again to another country if it benefits his career even if it means leaving another home.

For those who consider immigration, sam's advice is only do it if it's your last resort. And having a family present with you is going to make all the difference.

Finally Sam's story is a reminder that identity isn't just about where we come from, but about the people and experiences that shape us.